

Thunder and lightning

Hot, sticky summer days often end in violent thunderstorms. Dark, towering thunderclouds send forks of lightning flashing across the sky, and booming thunderclaps fill the air. The electricity from just one bolt of lightning could light a small town for a whole year!

Flash and crack

Inside a storm cloud, violent winds swirl snow, hailstones, and rain up and down. Electricity builds up in the cloud and escapes as a flash of lightning.

Lightning flashes between the bottom of the thundercloud and the ground.

Lightning and thunder happen at the same time, but you see the lightning first because light moves faster than sound. Thunder is the sound of air bursting as it is heated rapidly by lightning.